deserted me. When I met umpire Tucker later in the year he jokingly suggested to me that his friends were not happy with the decision and had given him a lot of grief for it. It was good of him to come and speak to me and we both decided to forget it and move on.

The Test series was followed by a five-match one-day series and I was looking to carry forward the form I had shown at The Oval. Just then, my shoulder injury really started to bother me again. Even when I was resting during the two Twenty20 matches, it showed no signs of settling down and I was forced to have an ultrasound-guided injection in the shoulder joint. It was in Durham on the eve of the first ODI that my toe also started to play up again during training. I did everything possible to settle the pain and took a few anti-inflammatory pills at night, but they didn't help and I woke the next morning feeling worse. I was feeling worried when we left the hotel on our way to the ground and as soon as we reached the stadium I asked Ashish Kaushik to strap my foot. The moment I stepped down from his physio table onto the hard tiles I suspected I was in trouble. When I tried getting into my spikes, I knew I couldn't play. At the end of the second Test match I had not been able to think of missing a game. Now the pain was such that I could not think of playing a game.

We decided to go to London for a fresh set of scans. I was given two injections in the sole of my foot and I must say they were two of the most painful injections I have had in my life. The doctors then informed me that I needed to rest my foot for five to six weeks. I finally started training again on the eve of the three-Test series against the West Indies at home in November 2011.

As soon as I resumed practice, the clamour for the 100th hundred started again.

West Indies in India, November–December 2011

By November 2011, the pressure had really started to get to me. Every day I was getting a lot of text messages wishing me well for the century and asking me not to worry. They were sent with the best of intentions, but unfortunately they made it impossible for me not to think about the landmark all the time. Everywhere I went people were talking about it – in hotels, restaurants, planes and airport lounges. While it was touching to see the affection, at times it began to get quite unbearable. It was